Employment prospects of Indian students studying in the US, Canada, Australia and Europe are now prominent in our agenda. Migration and mobility partnerships have been done with Portugal, UK, Australia, France, Germany and Italy, even as other European nations are starting to follow suit. In fact, in the period of Covid-induced uncertainties, the educational interests of students have become a subject of focus.

In terms of skills, we strive to ensure that Indian talent is treated in a non-discriminatory manner in the US, Canada, Oceania and Europe. Where they already reside, community welfare and cultural concerns, too, are a subject of our attention. The largest numbers with the greatest need are, of course, in the Gulf. Their well-being is of utmost priority, and that has been fully reflected in decision-making. The liberal usage of the Indian Community Welfare Fund (ICWF) speaks of a stronger sense of responsibility towards them, as do programmes for job training and creating facilities for those in distress. The agreement on rights of domestic workers signed with Kuwait is one illustration of our commitment to ensuring a better workplace abroad. Endeavours to get back social security payments made abroad is another. Indeed, making it easier to get visas has become much more central to our diplomatic efforts.

This mindset, in fact, goes back further up the chain, starting from how much easier it is now to get passports at home. By expanding the application centres four-fold and simplifying the verification process, the ability to travel and work abroad has undergone a sea change. Today, new prospects are opening up for Indian skills as a result of negotiated agreements, be it with Japan, Europe, the Gulf or Russia. Foreign policy is helping to make the world much more accessible to the average Indian. And they set out far more confidently than before, knowing that we have their back in times of difficulty. The Vande Bharat Mission, which brought back millions of Indians during the Covid waves, was as much a statement of capability as of commitment towards our workers and students, seafarers and tourists.

Those who have forayed into the world recently may have grown in numbers. But let us not forget that contemporary migrants join historically established communities to create the largest diaspora in the world. It is natural that their welfare and interest is connected deeply with foreign policy. As India’s global standing has gone up, they too have reaped the benefits of association. This is quite apart from the undoubted achievements